THE INDIAN DEFENDERS

Indian cyber-security agencies on the frontline

Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (14C)

Operating under the Union home ministry, it provides a framework to deal with cyber crime. During the recent attacks, it spearheaded counter-hack operations. Under it, over 150 hostile command-and-control servers were taken down

Data Security Council of India

Set up by NASSCOM, it is an industry body on data protection. During the cyber attacks that erupted after April 22, it led a joint task force, coordinating with government, private and industry bodies. It red-flagged suspicious sites, blocked vulnerable Indian sites

CERT-In

Working under the ministry of information technology, the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), is India's nodal agency dealing with cyber threats. It sent out alerts, emergency response procedures

NCIIPC

Functioning under the PMO, the National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre (NCIIPC) safeguards vital assets like power grids. Along with CERT-In, it picked out threats in the telecom, energy, finance and transport sectors, led a swift response using its expert teams

Defence Cyber Agency

India took the attack to the hackers too. Elite cyber units of the Defence Cyber Agency, a tri-service command of the Indian military, carried out retaliatory digital strikes on critical assets of the enemy. Took down social media troll farms, disrupted servers

but were thwarted. However, its hackers gained access to data of the Military Engineer Services and the Manohar Parrikar Institute of Defence Studies and Analyses. Most worryingly, confidential data, including upgrade plans for T-90 tanks and certain projects under development by the DRDO was put on sale on the dark web. APT *36* is believed to behind this intrusion too.

Other Pakistani groups like Team Insane Pakistan and HOAX1337 breached and defaced websites of the Assam Rifles, the Department of Atomic Energy and Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited, forcing them to go offline for a few days. The Pakistan Cyber Force hacked the Rajasthan education department's website, posting false claims about the Pahalgam terror attack.

Malaysian hacktivist groups like RipperSec launched social media propaganda campaigns to amplify anti-India narratives and targeted the vice president of India's website, while Turkish groups like the Turk Hack team carried out DDoS attacks on Indian banking websites and media portals. The Iranian hacker group Vulture carried out DDoS attacks on websites of CERT-In, the National Testing Agency, the office of the President of India and the Prime Minister's Office.

The Bangladeshi government denied involvement, but Indian cyber agencies traced ransomware and hacktivist attacks to hacker forums in Dhaka and Chittagong. Groups like Mysterious Bangladesh targeted government portals like those of the CBI, Election Commission and BSNL. It is suspected that non-state actors with ideological alignment to Pakistan were operating from Bangladesh.

China's cyber onslaught was more strategic. It conducted advanced persistent threats (APTs)—sophisticated and sustained cyber attacks that lodge themselves in a network—through groups like APT41 and Mustang Panda, attempting to disable India's power grids, logistics chains and telecommunications networks. A major concern was the attempted breach into India's railway network. Experts believe that Beijing's objective was to probe India's cyber resilience during a potential military standoff.

A decentralised group called R3V0XAnonymous launched abortive DDoS attacks on the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs and the Income Tax Department. Sensing the danger early on, the Bombay Stock Exchange issued a cyber-security advisory on May 7 following warnings from CERT-In about ongoing cyber threats targeting India's banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI) sector.

Power distribution networks in western India were also probed by malware variants, prompting precautionary shutdowns in some areas. On May 10, the official website of the Ulhasnagar Municipal Corporation in Maharashtra was hacked.

INDIA'S RESPONSE

Facing attacks on every domain, India's cyber armies—independent and state-backed—launched thousands of attacks on Pakistan. Indian hacking groups like Indian Cyber Force, Indian Cyber Defender, WhiteHorse and Cyber Warriors India claimed successful attacks on crucial Pakistani infrastructure. India's elite cyber unit under the Defence Cyber Agency—a tri-service command of the Indian military—was mobilised and retaliatory digital strikes were carried out on critical assets. This included takedowns of social media troll farms, disruption of servers and digital forensics operations to trace and expose the origin of attacks. Pakistan's NCERT (National Cyber Emergency Response Team) was forced to issue a red alert